

Shared strengths. Different patterns.

A practical guide for general education teachers working with English learners

START HERE

Spanish and English share sounds, word relationships, and ways to build meaning. They also organize some sounds and sentences differently. A student may understand a demanding idea while still learning how to express it in English. An accent is not a communication disorder. [1]

Notice	Check	Respond
Speech sounds A word sounds unfamiliar.	Can the student point to, write, or demonstrate the intended meaning?	Confirm the word and model it in a useful phrase.
Listening A direction is missed.	Was the language fast, unfamiliar, or packed with several steps?	Show the steps and ask the student to show the first action.
Sentence patterns Word order differs from the expected English form.	Is the content idea accurate?	Acknowledge the idea; offer one usable English model.

USE PATTERNS AS POSSIBILITIES

These are common comparisons, not predictions about every Spanish-speaking student. Dialect, schooling, other languages, and experience with English matter. Ask which languages the student uses and how they prefer to participate. [2,7]

Teacher move: “Show me what you mean.” Then: “Here is one way to say that in English.”

Sounds: what connects and changes

Start with familiar sounds, then teach the contrast the task requires.

What is similar	What is different	Classroom connection
Both use consonants and vowels. Shared consonants include sounds like m, f, and s. [2]	Spanish generally has five vowel categories; English has more, depending on dialect. [2,3]	Begin with familiar sounds. Then contrast ship/sheep using pictures and meaningful phrases.
Both put sounds into syllables. Students can listen for parts within a spoken word.	English permits more complex final consonant groups, as in texts. [2]	Say a useful word slowly, then in its full phrase. Do not assume an unclear cluster means the student does not know the word.
Both use stress and intonation. Voices highlight information and communicate intent.	Stress placement and vowel reduction do not match word for word. Unstressed English words may sound very short. [5]	Say: "Put it ON the desk." Point to the location. Then say the sentence naturally and ask the student to act.
Both connect sounds in fluent speech.	Boundaries between English words can be difficult to hear, even when the words are familiar in print. [5]	Pair a spoken direction with its written form. Pause between meaningful chunks, then repeat naturally.

TEACHER LANGUAGE

"You already use many of these sounds in Spanish. Let's listen for the part that changes in this English word." Similar does not mean identical: pronunciation varies within both languages.

Meaning: what connects and changes

Use Spanish knowledge as a starting point for English speech.

Shared foundation	Different pattern	Use the connection
Related vocabulary animal/animal information/información [8]	Cognates can share meaning without identical pronunciation. Look-alike words do not always share meaning.	Say both words. Connect each to the same picture or idea; confirm meaning in context.
Subjects, actions, objects Ana lee el libro. “Ana reads the book.”	Spanish can leave a clear subject unstated: Leo. English statements usually include it: “I read.” [6a]	Start with who + action + what. Model an English subject when needed.
One and more than one libro/libros “book/books”	Plural forms and their spoken endings do not always match. Spanish also marks agreement on many describing words. [6f]	Show one object and several. Practice the whole phrase, not only the final sound.
Describing words un libro interesante “an interesting book”	Many Spanish adjectives follow nouns and change for gender/number. English adjectives commonly precede nouns and do not show that agreement. [6b]	Say “interesting book” and “interesting books.” Keep interesting unchanged.
Questions and negatives Both languages ask and deny.	English often needs do/does/did where Spanish does not: ¿Lees? / “Do you read?” [6c,d]	Teach a reusable exchange: “Do you understand?” / “I don’t understand this part.”

BUILD A BRIDGE IN THREE MOVES

1. Notice something familiar. 2. Name one change. 3. Rehearse a meaningful English phrase.
Example: “Both languages describe books. Listen to where the describing word goes.”

Similar letters, different sounds

Listen for meaning first; practice a contrast when it helps communication.

Language difference	What you may notice	Helpful response
Vowels Spanish generally has five vowel categories. English has more; the inventory varies by dialect. [2,3]	Pairs such as ship/sheep or full/fool may be difficult to hear or produce distinctly.	Use a picture and a short phrase. Let the student identify the word before practicing it.
B and V In most Spanish varieties, the letters b and v represent the same phoneme. English usually distinguishes them. [4]	English words such as berry/very may sound similar.	For English v, model voiced airflow with upper teeth lightly touching the lower lip. For b, close the lips.
TH English has different th sounds in think and this. Spanish sounds vary by dialect and position. [2]	A student may substitute another sound. Do not assume every Spanish speaker lacks these sounds.	Choose a needed word, model it slowly, then return to its meaningful sentence.
R Spanish taps and trills differ from the r common in U.S. English. Both languages vary by dialect. [2]	An English word may have a tapped or trilled r.	If meaning is clear, continue the discussion. Practice a word privately if the student wants support.

A TWO-MINUTE ROUTINE

Show two meanings → say one word → student points → use the word in a sentence. Avoid public “say it again” drills that turn participation into a pronunciation test.

What changes in a whole sentence?

Spoken language is a stream of sounds, not a list of printed words.

1 CONSONANTS CAN CLUSTER

English permits complex groups of consonants, especially at the ends of words; Spanish generally permits fewer. Words such as asked and texts may be difficult to pronounce clearly. Model the whole phrase, with time to rehearse. [2]

2 SMALL ENDINGS CARRY MEANING

Listen for book/books, walk/walked, and she walks. A hard-to-hear ending does not by itself show that the student lacks the idea of number or time. Spanish also marks number and verb agreement. Check meaning with “one or more?” or a timeline.

3 WORDS CHANGE IN CONNECTED SPEECH

Both languages link sounds in speech. English also commonly reduces unstressed words: to may sound like “tuh” in a phrase. A familiar printed word may be hard to recognize in a fast sentence. Teach listening recognition without requiring students to imitate every reduction. [5]

CLASSROOM SCENE: “TURN IN YOUR LAB REPORT.”

Teacher: Say the direction naturally, then pause between meaningful chunks.

Board: 1. Write your name. 2. Submit the report.

Check: “Show me step one.” A yes to “Do you understand?” gives less information than a demonstration.

Transfer can shape a sentence

Offer a useful model while keeping the student's idea at the center.

Spanish pattern	Possible English	Teacher model
Subject can be unstated Estudio biología. [6a]	"Study biology."	"I study biology." English statements usually need a subject; commands can omit it.
Many adjectives follow nouns un libro interesante Some precede them. [6b]	"a book interesting"	"an interesting book" Place the describing word before the noun in this phrase.
Questions do not use English-style do ¿Estudias aquí? [6c]	"You study here?" This can be valid conversational English.	For an interview task: "Do you study here?" Teach a form suited to the purpose.
No before the verb No entiendo. [6d]	"I no understand."	"I don't understand this step." Give a phrase the student can reuse immediately.
Age uses tener Tengo dieciséis años. [6e]	"I have sixteen years."	"I am sixteen years old." Teach the whole expression.

FEEDBACK THAT KEEPS THE CONVERSATION GOING

Student: "The water disappear." Teacher: "Yes, the water evaporates. Explain where it goes."
Later, rehearse one agreed-on sentence pattern. Avoid correcting every feature during a content discussion.

Same content goal. Different support.

Newcomer, emerging, and progressing describe support needs here—not fixed identities.

SHARED SCIENCE GOAL

Explain why a puddle becomes smaller as liquid water evaporates into water vapor.

Words to display: water / agua · liquid / líquido · water vapor / vapor de agua · evaporate / evaporarse

Support level	Participation and language support
Newcomer	Use a drawing with arrows. Allow pointing and Spanish planning. Model: “Liquid water becomes water vapor.” / “El agua líquida se convierte en vapor de agua.” Offer a word bank and partner rehearsal.
Emerging	Offer: “The puddle gets smaller because ____.” / “El charco se hace más pequeño porque ____.” Invite one spoken explanation after rehearsal. Model a needed verb or ending.
Progressing	Ask for two or three connected sentences using because and as a result. Ask the student to explain what happens to the water and revise one phrase for clarity.

CHECK THE SAME IDEA AT EVERY LEVEL

Can the student show that liquid water changes into water vapor? Evaluate the science separately from the English feature being practiced. Adjust scaffolds by the task; a student may need more help listening than explaining a familiar diagram.

60-second feedback: Listen → confirm the idea → model one phrase → invite another try. Permit a pass and a return after rehearsal.

Keep this beside your lesson plan

A quick reference for everyday classroom conversations

When you hear or see...	Try this...
An unfamiliar pronunciation	"Do you mean ___?" Offer writing, pointing, or an example.
A missing or unclear ending	Check time or number first. Then model the ending in a short phrase.
Confusion after a direction	Write the steps, pause, and ask the student to demonstrate the first one.
Unexpected sentence order	Respond to the idea, then recast one sentence naturally.
A long pause	Allow planning time and partner rehearsal. Avoid completing every sentence.
A very direct request	Teach a phrase for the setting: "May I borrow a pencil, please?" / "¿Me prestas un lápiz, por favor?" Do not infer disrespect from a single phrasing.

MAKE CLASSROOM NORMS EXPLICIT

Tone, volume, pauses, and ways of requesting help vary across individuals and settings. Explain what works in your classroom and why. Ask about intent rather than assuming attitude. Cognates such as energy/energía can support meaning, even when pronunciation differs. [1,7]

WHEN MORE SUPPORT MAY BE NEEDED

Document examples across tasks and settings. Collaborate with the EL teacher, family, and appropriate specialists. Persistent concerns require attention to all languages used; an accent or one English sample is not enough to identify a disorder. [7]

The one-page language bridge

Similarity → difference → what you might hear → a helpful response

Shared feature	Different pattern	You may hear	Try saying
Vowels in both languages	English has more vowel categories. [2,3]	A word between ship and sheep.	"Point to the picture you mean. Yes, a ship."
Related words	Meaning may connect while pronunciation changes. [8]	A Spanish-like pronunciation of information.	"Información, information: related words. What information do we need?"
Subjects and verbs	Spanish can omit a clear subject. [6a]	"Need help." Also possible as informal English.	For a full request: "I need help with step two."
Describing words	Adjective order often differs. [6b]	"a solution different"	"A different solution. Show us how it works."
Singular and plural	Endings and agreement differ. [6b,f]	"two book"	"Two books. Which two?" Check the number before focusing on the ending.
Questions and negatives	English often uses do/does/did. [6c,d]	"I no understand."	"I don't understand this part. Can you show me which part?"
Connected speech	English weak forms can hide familiar words. [5]	"What?" after a fast direction.	Pause and show: "Open your book. Find page ten."

REMEMBER

These examples are possibilities, not a checklist for identifying Spanish speakers. Similar utterances can have several causes. Ask about meaning before deciding what support is needed.

Three conversations, better outcomes

Comic-style dialogue panels • Original classroom examples

1 SCIENCE: HEAR THE IDEA

STUDENT SAYS

"The water go in air."

TEACHER RESPONDS

"You mean the liquid water becomes water vapor. Show where it goes in your diagram."

Possible misreading: "The student does not understand evaporation."

Check the idea: Ask the student to label liquid and water vapor and explain the arrow.

2 ENGLISH: MODEL THE PHRASE

STUDENT SAYS

"The character afraid because hide."

TEACHER RESPONDS

"You infer that the character is afraid because they hide. Which line supports that?"

Possible misreading: "The student has no inference."

Check the idea: The claim needs evidence. Ask for a line, then rehearse "I infer ___ because ___."

3 DIRECTIONS: MAKE THE TASK VISIBLE

STUDENT SAYS

"I no know what do."

TEACHER RESPONDS

"Let's find the first step. Circle the claim. Show me what you will circle."

Possible misreading: "The student was not listening."

Check the idea: Have the student demonstrate step one. Then add the next direction.

Use it in every subject

Keep the content objective the same; adjust the language support.

ENGLISH • SUPPORT AN INFERENCE

Materials: Your current class text and two marked passages.

Task: Infer a character's motive and cite a relevant line.

Frame: "I infer ___ because the text says ___." / "Infiero ___ porque el texto dice ___."

Check: Student identifies a line and explains how it supports the inference.

SCIENCE • EXPLAIN A PROCESS

Materials: A puddle sketch, arrows, and liquid/water vapor labels.

Task: Explain evaporation.

Frame: "The liquid water becomes ___." / "El agua líquida se convierte en ___."

Check: Student connects liquid water to water vapor; probe "Where is the water now?"

HISTORY • COMPARE WITH EVIDENCE

Materials: Two accounts already assigned in your lesson.

Task: Compare how the accounts describe the same event.

Frame: "Both accounts ___, but only account A ___." / "Ambos relatos ___, pero solo el relato A ___."

Check: Student locates one supporting detail in each account.

MATH • EXPLAIN REASONING

Materials: $2x + 6 = 14$ displayed with space for steps.

Task: Solve and justify each operation.

Frame: "I subtract 6 from both sides because ___." / "Resto 6 de ambos lados porque ___."

Check: Student explains keeping the sides equal and checks $x = 4$ in the original equation.

Correct now, model, or return later?

An instructional decision guide—not a rule to interrupt every error

CLARIFY NOW • THE MEANING IS UNCLEAR

Ask a neutral question: “Do you mean one book or two?” Offer pointing, drawing, writing, or Spanish planning. For a safety direction, check the action before proceeding. Clarification is about understanding the message.

MODEL BRIEFLY • TODAY’S LANGUAGE TARGET IS INVOLVED

If the goal is explaining yesterday’s procedure, model a past-tense phrase: “Yesterday, we measured the water.” Invite a short retry after acknowledging the content. Limit feedback to one useful feature.

RETURN LATER • MEANING IS CLEAR AND IDEAS ARE FLOWING

During discussion, respond to the reasoning and keep listening. Note a phrase for a private conference or the next mini-lesson. Do not make every contribution a grammar exercise.

Student response	Teacher decision	Possible words
“Two result is same.”	Meaning is clear; probe reasoning.	“The two results are the same. How did you check?”
“It more.”	Meaning is unclear; clarify now.	“More mass, more volume, or more time? Show me.”
“Yesterday we measure.”	If past time is today’s target, model and retry.	“Yesterday we measured. Tell your partner what you measured.”

Exit question for the teacher: Did my feedback help the student communicate or understand the content more clearly?

Phrase bank: getting into the conversation

English / Spanish • Offer a frame, model it aloud, and allow rehearsal.

Purpose / support	English phrase	Spanish meaning
CLARIFY • Newcomer	"Please repeat."	"Repíte, por favor."
CLARIFY • Emerging	"What does ___ mean?"	"¿Qué significa ___?"
CLARIFY • Progressing	"Do you mean ___, or do you mean ___?"	"¿Quieres decir ___ o ___?"
GET HELP • Newcomer	"Help, please."	"Ayuda, por favor."
GET HELP • Emerging	"I need help with ___."	"Necesito ayuda con ___."
GET HELP • Progressing	"I completed ___, but I am unsure how to ___."	"Completé ___, pero no sé bien cómo ___."
JOIN IN • Newcomer	"My turn?"	"¿Me toca?"
JOIN IN • Emerging	"May I add an idea?"	"¿Puedo añadir una idea?"
JOIN IN • Progressing	"I would like to build on ___'s idea."	"Me gustaría ampliar la idea de ___."

HOW TO USE THIS PAGE

Newcomer: point to a phrase and echo or read it. Emerging: complete a blank with a word bank. Progressing: adapt the phrase and add detail. These supports are flexible, not proficiency test descriptors.

Phrase bank: explain and respond

Keep the reasoning goal; give students the language to share it.

Purpose / support	English phrase	Spanish meaning
EXPLAIN • Newcomer	"My answer is ____."	"Mi respuesta es ____."
EXPLAIN • Emerging	"I think ____ because ____."	"Pienso que ____ porque ____."
EXPLAIN • Progressing	"The evidence supports ____ because ____."	"La evidencia respalda ____ porque ____."
DISAGREE • Newcomer	"I think ____."	"Pienso que ____."
DISAGREE • Emerging	"I see it differently because ____."	"Lo veo de otra manera porque ____."
DISAGREE • Progressing	"I understand your point; however, ____ suggests ____."	"Entiendo tu punto de vista; sin embargo, ____ sugiere ____."
COMPARE • Newcomer	"Both have ____."	"Ambos tienen ____."
COMPARE • Emerging	"Both ____, but only ____."	"Ambos ____, pero solo ____."
COMPARE • Progressing	"Although both ____, they differ in ____."	"Aunque ambos ____, se diferencian en ____."

MAKE THE EXCHANGE REAL

Partner A explains an answer. Partner B asks one clarification question or offers a different interpretation. Switch roles. Accept a short response first, then invite evidence or detail. Spanish phrasing may be adapted to local usage.

Teacher practice: hear the thinking

8-minute individual or team activity • Suggested responses on the next page

DIRECTIONS

For each case, identify: (1) what the student has shown, (2) what remains uncertain, and (3) one response that checks content and supports language. Choose whether to clarify now, model briefly, or return to language later.

CASE A • TWO SOLUTIONS

Task: Solve $2x + 6 = 14$ and explain.

Student points to $x = 4$ and says: "I take six both side. Then divide two."

What does this show? What would you ask next?

Notes: _____

CASE B • EVIDENCE IN A TEXT

Task: Infer a character's feelings using evidence.

Student says: "He angry," but has not selected a line.

What can you conclude? What is still missing?

Notes: _____

CASE C • A MISSED DIRECTION

Task: Underline the claim and circle supporting evidence.

After a fast oral direction, the student circles the entire paragraph.

How will you separate a listening barrier from a content misunderstanding?

Notes: _____

Teacher practice: suggested responses

Several responses can work. Look for evidence before drawing a conclusion.

CASE A • ACKNOWLEDGE AND PROBE

Shown: Correct solution and a sequence of valid operations.

Uncertain: Whether the student can explain why both sides receive the same operation.

Try: “You subtracted six from both sides, then divided by two. Why both sides?” Allow a balance drawing or Spanish planning.

Decision: Model briefly; prioritize the mathematical reasoning.

CASE B • ASK FOR THE EVIDENCE

Shown: A claim about a character’s feeling.

Uncertain: Whether the claim fits the text and whether the student can support it.

Try: “Show me a line that makes you think he is angry.” Then offer: “I infer ___ because ___.”

Decision: Probe content now. Do not treat the short sentence alone as proof of weak comprehension.

CASE C • CHECK ONE ACTION AT A TIME

Shown: The student attempted the task; the marks do not yet distinguish claim from evidence.

Uncertain: Listening, vocabulary, or concept knowledge may be involved.

Try: Display “1. Underline the claim.” Model the action on a different sentence. Ask the student to identify the claim, then add the evidence step.

Decision: Clarify now and reassess after support.

PLAN ONE CHANGE FOR TOMORROW

My content objective: _____

One phrase I will display: _____

How students will show understanding: _____

You belong in this classroom

Helping Spanish-speaking students feel welcome in general education

KNOW THE PERSON, NOT JUST THE LANGUAGE

Ask privately which name and pronunciation the student uses, which languages they use, and what interests them. Spanish-speaking students have different identities and experiences; some use additional languages. Do not assume nationality, immigration history, or literacy from language alone. [7,9]

When	What the teacher does	What the student can count on
Before arrival	Prepare a seat in the learning group, supplies, a visual agenda, and a simple map. Choose a willing, patient peer buddy.	A clear place to sit and a way to get started.
First five minutes	Greet the student by name. Show materials and one manageable task. Ask before a public introduction.	A welcome without a surprise speech in front of the class.
During the lesson	Pair a meaningful task with a picture, model, and sentence frame. Invite Spanish planning and English rehearsal.	Grade-level thinking with a supported way to participate.
Before dismissal	Show where work goes and what to bring next time. Check one action rather than asking only “Understand?”	Knowing how to finish and what happens next.
During week one	Check privately about partners, routines, and interests. Offer information about a club or activity the student chooses.	More than one connection to the classroom and school.

BELONGING IS AN EVERYDAY ROUTINE

Names, home-language visibility, predictable routines, and peer connections are recommended starting points. [9] The schedule above is an original planning example; adapt it with the student and your EL teacher.

Make the welcome visible and audible

Small teacher moves students can use right away

Purpose	English	Spanish
Welcome	"I'm glad you're here."	"Me alegra que estés aquí."
Learn the name	"How do you pronounce your name?"	"¿Cómo se pronuncia tu nombre?"
Offer support	"Would you like to practice with a partner first?"	"¿Quieres practicar primero con un compañero o una compañera?"
Allow thinking time	"Take a moment to think."	"Tómate un momento para pensar."
Value the home language	"You can plan your idea in Spanish first."	"Puedes preparar tu idea en español primero."
Check comfort privately	"What would help you in this class?"	"¿Qué te ayudaría en esta clase?"

A PEER BUDDY IS A CONNECTION

Give a willing buddy a specific role: show the materials, explain a routine, or rehearse a response. Check whether the partnership works and vary partners over time. The teacher remains responsible for instruction. Use an adult interpreter for family meetings and sensitive conversations. [9]

INCLUDE WITHOUT PUTTING ON THE SPOT

Invite students to share interests or experiences; allow them to decline. Do not ask one student to represent all Spanish speakers or translate every lesson. Include varied people and perspectives throughout the year. Address accent jokes or exclusion promptly: "We respect people's names, languages, and voices here."

Visible supports: Materials / Materiales · Turn in work / Entrega de trabajos · Today's plan / Plan de hoy. Pair labels with pictures and demonstrate their use.

Listen, connect, and follow through

A student check-in and a teacher checklist for the first week

PRIVATE STUDENT CHECK-IN • ENGLISH / ESPAÑOL

You may answer by speaking, writing, pointing, or drawing. You may skip a question.
Puedes responder hablando, escribiendo, señalando o dibujando. Puedes omitir una pregunta.

The name I use / El nombre que uso: _____

Languages I use / Idiomas que uso: _____

Something I enjoy / Algo que disfruto: _____

What helps me learn / Lo que me ayuda a aprender: _____

Teacher check	Concrete follow-through
Does the student know how to get help?	Teach a phrase or agreed-on signal. Check that it works during a real task.
Is the student part of the group?	Give a meaningful role such as selecting evidence or checking a solution, with language support.
Can the student show knowledge today?	Offer a diagram, short oral response, bilingual notes, or partner rehearsal linked to the same content goal.
Have I connected with the family?	Ask their preferred language and communication method. Use school interpretation support; share one specific strength.
Did I act on the student's feedback?	Choose one requested support, use it, and ask whether it helped.

FRIDAY CHECK • ASK PRIVATELY

"Can you show me how you ask for help? Is there someone you feel comfortable working with? What should we change next week?" Record one action to take. Check belonging through conversation, not a public survey of who has friends.

Common errors: everyday sentences

Six useful teaching targets • Examples are illustrative, not a frequency ranking.

Some patterns may reflect Spanish-English differences; others occur across language backgrounds. Confirm the intended meaning before choosing a model.

You may hear	English model	Quick teaching move
1. Age with have “I have sixteen years.”	“I am sixteen years old.”	Connect Tengo dieciséis años to the whole English phrase “I am ___ years old.” [6e]
2. Adjective after noun “a question difficult”	“a difficult question”	Point to two word cards: difficult + question. Let the student describe another classroom item. [6b]
3. Plural adjective “two difficults questions”	“two difficult questions”	Keep the describing word unchanged: one difficult question / two difficult questions. Spanish adjective agreement differs. [6b]
4. Missing plural ending “three pencil”	“three pencils”	Show three objects; confirm the number, then say the full phrase. An unclear final sound may also be a pronunciation issue.
5. No before a verb “I no understand.”	“I don’t understand.”	Teach “I don’t understand ___” as a reusable help phrase. Contrast No entiendo. [6d,10]
6. Missing be in a statement “My partner absent today.”	“My partner is absent today.”	Model person + is + description. Do not explain this as Spanish lacking a verb for “be”; Spanish uses ser and estar.

ONE FEATURE AT A TIME

Acknowledge the idea, model one useful phrase, and invite a brief retry. Return to the content question. These models support classroom English; consider conversational context and the student’s language varieties.

Common errors: verbs and questions

Teach a small pattern, then use it in a real classroom exchange.

You may hear	English model	Quick teaching move
7. Missing third-person ending "She explain the answer."	"She explains the answer."	Contrast "I explain" and "She explains." Use one familiar verb in a meaningful sentence. [10]
8. Extra ending after does "Does he needs help?"	"Does he need help?"	Model does + person + base verb. Compare "He needs help" with "Does he need help?" [10]
9. Do with be "Do you are ready?"	"Are you ready?"	Practice "Are you ready?" / "Yes, I am." Contrast with "Do you need help?" / "Yes, I do." [10]
10. Past-time form "Yesterday we measure the water."	"Yesterday we measured the water."	Use a timeline and the phrase "Yesterday we ____." First check whether the ending was absent or simply hard to hear. [11]
11. Regular ending on an irregular verb "We goed to the lab."	"We went to the lab."	Pair go / went in two short sentences. This can reflect applying an English pattern too broadly, not direct Spanish transfer. [11]
12. Past form after did "Did you finished?"	"Did you finish?"	Pair "You finished" with "Did you finish?" In this question, did carries the past marking; use the base verb after it. [11]

PRACTICE IN 60 SECONDS

Model: "Did you finish?" Student chooses a truthful answer: "Yes, I did" or "Not yet." Add meaning: "I finished ____." Repeat with a partner, then return to the task. Use the exchange only when it fits the lesson.

Not everything needs correcting

Use context, meaning, and the learning goal to choose your response.

What you hear	How to interpret it	Helpful response
"You finished?"	This can be a natural conversational question. It is not automatically an error.	For a formal interview task, also teach "Did you finish?" Explain when that model is useful.
"Need help?" or "Ready?"	Shortened expressions are common in conversation.	Respond naturally. Teach a full sentence when the task calls for one.
An r or vowel sounds different, but the word is clear.	Accent differences alone are not grammar errors or evidence of a disorder. [1]	Respond to the idea. Offer pronunciation support when it improves clarity or the student requests it.
A student uses a Spanish word inside an English explanation.	The student may be using available language to keep the idea moving.	Confirm meaning and supply the needed English word without dismissing the explanation.
A pause or a short response	One response does not tell you whether the barrier is language, content, confidence, or task clarity.	Allow rehearsal, a visual, or a follow-up question; then check the content again.

CHOOSE THE NEXT STEP

Newcomer: Offer the complete useful phrase and a picture or gesture.

Emerging: Leave one blank and provide two or three word choices.

Progressing: Invite the student to notice and revise one pattern, then elaborate the idea.

Teacher reminder: Avoid labeling a student by an error pattern. Keep a brief note of the phrase being practiced and listen for it again in a later, meaningful task.

Sources and scope

Primary professional resources and university grammar references

This guide offers classroom comparisons and original teaching examples. It is not a diagnostic tool or a complete account of Spanish or English dialects. Most English pronunciation examples reflect common U.S. usage. Links support the numbered references in the guide.

- 1** ASHA — Accent Modification · [Open source](#)
Accent, intelligibility, and listener factors. Adult practice resource; general principles used here.
- 2** ASHA — Spanish Phonemic Inventory · [Open source](#)
Broad sound-system comparison. Individual dialects may differ.
- 3** García & Froud (2018) — English vowel perception · [Open source](#)
Research on adult sequential Spanish-English bilinguals; not a school screening standard.
- 4** FundéuRAE — b, v, w: pronunciation · [Open source](#)
Spanish b/v pronunciation, including exceptions related to language contact.
- 5** British Council — Connected speech, part 1 · [Open source](#)
Weak forms and listening to speech across word boundaries.
- 6** Bowdoin College / Enrique Yepes — Spanish Grammar · [Open source](#)
6a: §§4–5, subjects; 6b: §11, adjectives; 6c: §12, questions; 6d: §§8–10, negation; 6e: §§13–15, tener; 6f: §§6–7, number.
- 7** ASHA — Multilingual Service Delivery · [Open source](#)
Language history, cultural context, and distinguishing language differences from disorders.
- 8** Colorín Colorado — Cognates · [Open source](#)
Related words as a bridge between languages; verify meaning in context.
- 9** Colorín Colorado — Welcoming students and languages · [Open source](#)
Names, routines, peer connections, interests, and welcoming home languages.
- 10** British Council — Present simple · [Open source](#)
Verb forms, questions, and negatives.
- 11** British Council — Past simple · [Open source](#)
Regular and irregular past forms; questions with did.

Additional reading: [British Council: English as a lingua franca](#) — listening awareness and communication goals.

Prepared October 2026. Teacher routines and sample classroom dialogues are original illustrations, not quotations.